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How social science academics use AI

Activities and tools

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WHY THIS STUDY

Nobody had asked the researchers themselves

Generative AI research is dominated by computer scientists. Social scientists are among the least active users — and Lithuania sits near the bottom of the EU's AI R&D activity score. The authors call their case doubly lagging.

33 / 200

Google Scholar publications (2023–24) matching “generative AI” + “social sciences” that actually concerned AI use in scientific research

Review

Almost half of the relevant literature is review articles. Most of the rest studies students and teaching, not researchers

13

social scientists interviewed at Vilnius University — the study this paper reports

Research problem: how does Lithuania's social sciences academic community experience the use of AI in academic activities?

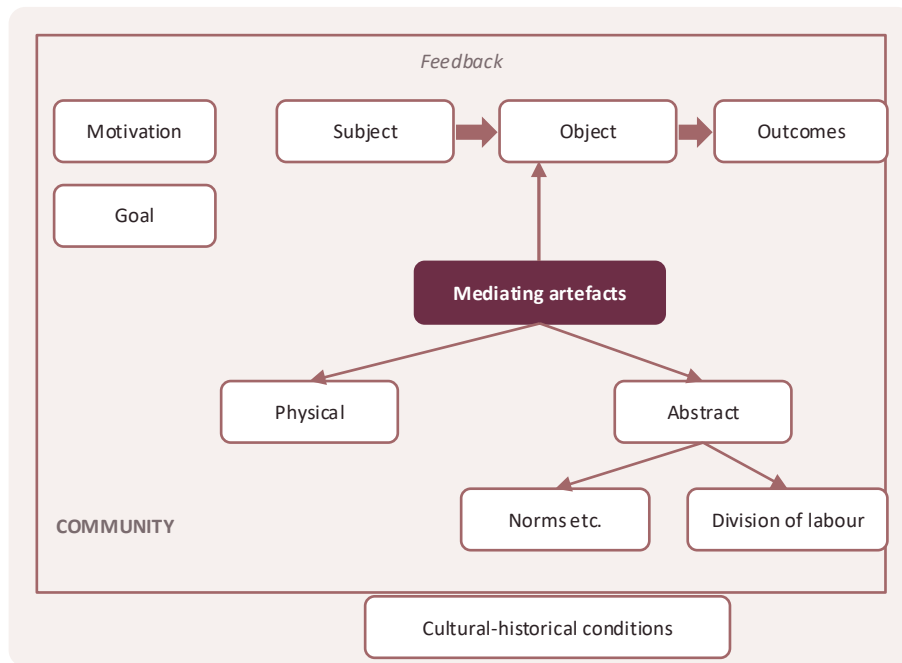
Three sub-questions: needs and motives · AI's perceived role and value · the rules and norms emerging in the community

Activity theory: AI as a mediating artefact

Vygotsky, 1930s; developed by Engeström. A subject works on an object through instruments, inside a community with its own norms and division of labour.

The authors use T.D. Wilson's version, which adds feedback loops and cultural-historical conditions.

The payoff: AI adoption becomes a question about human behaviour, not about technology — and the framework's real value is naming the tensions between elements.



Thirteen interviews at Vilnius University

Who

13 social scientists across data management, information security, legal regulation, computational linguistics, digital heritage, history, and political and cultural sociology.

How they were found

Purposive sampling — convenience plus snowballing, starting from colleagues known to the authors. Chosen for technical competence and diversity of AI use.

The interviews

Semi-structured, in three blocks matching activity theory. Piloted with two respondents, conducted remotely over Teams, stopped at theoretical saturation.

The analysis

Content analysis. Coding led by the framework but open to new categories; two researchers coded and cross-reviewed. Respondents reported as R1–R13.

The motive is time, not capability

Nobody adopted AI to do better sociology. They adopted it to stop doing the routine work — and to get help with tasks that used to require paying someone else.

The three most common tasks

Searching for sources and literature · Translation · Editing

Plus the “invisible work”: e-mails, administrative summaries, anything tedious.

“

If you are entirely lost and do not know what to write or what to do, AI can help in brainstorming and suggest ideas, though they may be presented in a standard bulleted list form.

— R10

14

AI tools named — ChatGPT and DeepL through Elicit, Litmaps and a self-built assistant

1–3

tools most respondents use regularly

2 of 13

had never used AI for work at all

“An inexperienced research assistant”

“

It's like really as a helper, like a very lowly research assistant, inexperienced research assistant, to do tasks that I really don't have the time to do.

— R7

“

I am training my scientist, i.e., digital twin. My trained twin can advise me.

— R3

Used at the front of the pipeline — initial search, first pass — then validated independently.

Where it breaks down

- No originality — “all abstracts follow the same pattern”
- Strips the context that content and documentary analysis depend on
- No feel for the emotional dimension of social research
- Hallucinated, uncited sources
- SPSS, not AI, is still the primary working tool

Rules exist. Awareness of them doesn't.

Vilnius University's Senate approved AI usage guidelines on 18 June 2024 — but they address education. For research they say little beyond “follow academic ethics and publishers' rules.”

Respondents did not know the guidelines existed. All the same, every respondent said AI use should meet the same ethical standards as any research.

“*It is unethical to use AI-generated texts because it already plagiarises when presenting text, as the sources it relies upon are not disclosed, not cited, or are hallucinated.*

— R2

The norms they name

- Plagiarism
- Attribution of authorship
- Integrity in data processing
- Protection and security

Where researchers actually meet regulation: submitting to journals. Norms otherwise emerge through university working parties and committees.

Three tensions, two contradictions

In activity theory, tensions are the visible symptoms of deeper contradictions — and they develop the system only when someone notices and works through them.

1

Efficiency vs. competence

Delegating saves time — but erodes the expertise needed to judge what comes back.

2

Rigour vs. output quality

Research needs accuracy and reproducibility; AI omits context and varies by version.

3

Practice vs. regulation

Norms are unclear and unevenly known, so caution comes from uncertainty, not conviction.

CONTRADICTION 1

AI is seen as genuinely useful, yet distrusted because these systems are opaque.

CONTRADICTION 2

The community wants AI's research value universally recognised — but unequal access and expertise keep pulling that apart.

Their remedy: institutional support — access to good tools, AI-literacy training, clearer guidance.

What they admit — and what I'd add

Their limitations

- 13 interviews at one institution in one country
- Self-reported data, open to bias
- A snapshot — usage was shifting as they wrote
- Echoes elsewhere don't cancel the sampling bias

My additions

- The sample skews to information-adjacent fields — these are not typical social scientists
- Snowballed from the authors' own colleagues in their own faculty
- Coding was framework-first: the tensions are the theory's category, not the respondents'
- No dates given for when the interviews happened

Three things worth carrying out

1

Adoption is about time, not capability

These researchers use AI to clear routine work — search, translation, editing, e-mail — not to do better research. That reframes what “adoption” means.

2

The limit is judgement, not access

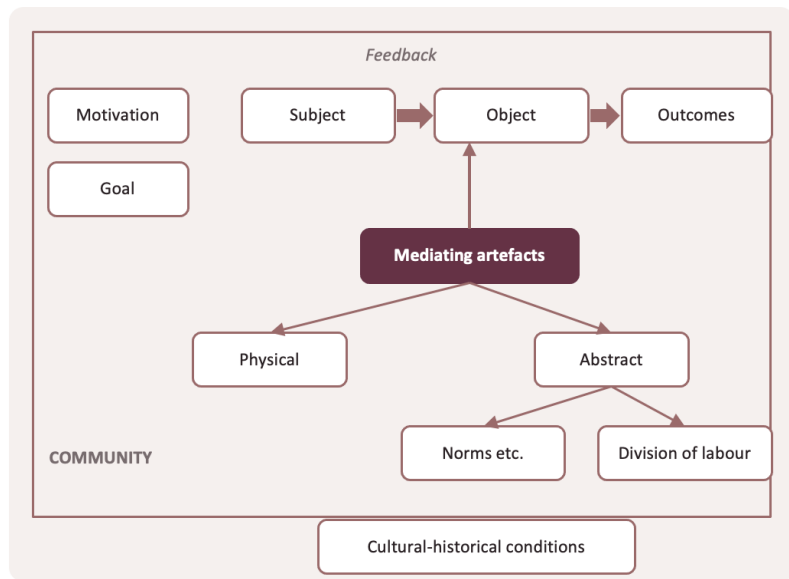
They had the tools and still used AI only at the front of the pipeline, because you need the expertise to check the output — the expertise you hoped to save.

3

Policy is aimed at the wrong people

Institutional AI guidance is written for students and assessment. Researchers get their real constraints from journal submission rules.

Where AI went wrong: a human critique of the presented output



1. The diagram on **slide 3** (shown on the left) is a replication of figure 1 on page 5 (shown on the right). The recreation simplified and omitted much of what was originally represented. (i.e., feedback arrows are removed, which makes the process more difficult to internalize for readers)

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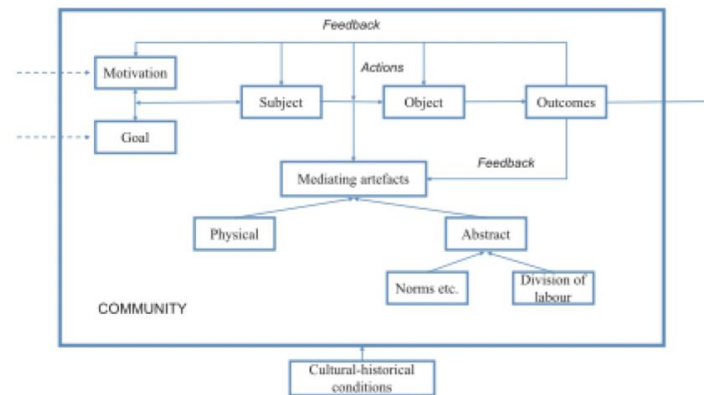


Figure 1. A process model of activity theory [31].

Where AI went wrong: a human critique of the presented output

2. An AI summary reads as hyper-confident “some respondents” becomes “respondents,” and AI converts what is labeled by the authors as a tentative finding into a hardened claim. (**slide 7**). Additionally, the header on **slide 7** presents findings as absolute “Rules exist. Awareness of them doesn’t doesn’t.” The paper says “a significant scarcity of empirical research.”



Rules exist. Awareness of them doesn't.

Respondents did not know the guidelines existed. All the same, every respondent said AI use should meet the same ethical standards as any research.

Where AI went wrong: a human critique of the presented output

3. It attributed its own additions to me! For example, in **slide 9**, “what I’d add” and “my additions.” The output did not make clear that it was its own production, not MINE! This seems like a potential plagiarism issue, as it is presenting the information as an original human contribution, rather than one generated by AI



What they admit — and what I'd add

My additions

- The sample skews to information-adjacent fields — these are not typical social scientists

Where AI went wrong: a criticism of the presented output — AI Checking itself — I asked Claude if I missed any of its mistakes

4. Slide 5 says **"sociology"** about a sample that isn't **sociologists**. *"Nobody adopted AI to do better sociology."*

The 13 respondents are computational linguists, historians, legal scholars, information security and digital heritage researchers. Two of thirteen are described as sociologists. The AI reached for the nearest disciplinary word — and it happens to be *your* discipline, which is worth noticing: the error slid past you partly because it sounded natural to you.

Where AI went wrong: a criticism of the presented output — AI Checking itself — I asked Claude if I missed any of its mistakes

5. **Slides 8 and 10 contradict each other.** Slide 8 presents Contradiction 2: *"unequal access and expertise keep pulling that apart."* Slide 10 then declares: *"The limit is judgement, not access."* The deck asserts access is a constraint, then two slides later asserts it isn't. Neither statement is flagged as an inference. This is the most useful error in the set, because it shows the failure isn't per-sentence — each slide was drafted to be locally punchy, and nothing checked whether the deck was consistent with itself. A human writing ten slides holds the argument in their head. The model held ten slides.